

A NEXDYNE READINESS TOOL

The SMB AI Readiness Guide

10 Questions to Answer Before Investing in AI, Automation, or New
Technology

*A practical decision framework for business leaders who want
results — not another technology experiment.*

Most companies start in the wrong place.

They ask, “**Which AI tool should we buy?**” The better question — the one that actually predicts whether the investment pays off — is “**Is our business ready to use it?**”

Technology cannot compensate for an unclear process, scattered data, missing ownership, or absent human oversight. Point AI at those gaps and it doesn't fix them — it amplifies them, faster and at scale.

Readiness isn't only *technical* readiness. It's also judgment, process clarity, accountability, governance, workforce capability, and measurement. That's the heart of how we see it at NexDyne: **human intelligence, governed and scaled** — technology that makes good people faster, inside a business that's ready to use it responsibly.

How to use this guide

Ten questions follow. Score each one, add them up, and read your band at the end. Bring it to a leadership meeting. It takes about fifteen minutes and will tell you — before you spend a dollar — whether you're ready to invest, or whether a little groundwork will make that investment pay off far more.

0 Not in place **1** Partially in place **2** Clearly in place

THE 10 READINESS QUESTIONS

1 Is the business problem clearly defined?

SCORE

WHY IT MATTERS

AI on a vague problem gives a vague result. The projects that succeed start from a specific, costly pain — not from “we should use AI.”

WARNING SIGNS

You can name the tool you want, but not the cost, delay, or error it's meant to fix.

READY WHEN

You can say in one sentence what you're solving, who feels it, how often, and what “better” looks like.

DO THIS

Write a one-sentence problem statement before you evaluate a single tool. If you can't, that's your first project.

2 Is the underlying process stable and documented?

SCORE

WHY IT MATTERS

Automating a process that changes every week — or lives only in one person's head — just automates chaos.

WARNING SIGNS

“It depends who's doing it.” No written steps. It changed three times this quarter.

READY WHEN

It runs the same way most of the time, the steps are written down, and the common exceptions are known.

DO THIS

Document the process end-to-end in plain steps before automating it — you'll often find fixes worth more than the AI.

3 Do you have usable, accessible data?

SCORE 0 1 2

WHY IT MATTERS

AI runs on your data. If it's scattered, inconsistent, or locked where nobody can reach it, the tool inherits — and amplifies — every one of those problems.

READY WHEN

The data the task needs is identifiable, reasonably clean, and reachable — not perfect, but usable for the job.

DO THIS

For your target task, list exactly what data it needs and where it lives. Fix the worst inconsistency before you start.

WARNING SIGNS

The same customer exists three times under three spellings. Key info lives in one person's spreadsheet. Systems don't talk.

4 Do your people understand the process today?

SCORE 0 1 2

WHY IT MATTERS

Technology can't compensate for a process the team doesn't understand. If they can't explain the work, they can't tell whether the AI is doing it right.

READY WHEN

Several people understand it, can explain it, and could spot a wrong output.

DO THIS

Have two people who don't own the process describe it. The gaps between their answers are your risk.

WARNING SIGNS

Only one person “just knows how it works.” New hires take months. Nobody can explain why a step exists.

5

Will someone own the system after it goes live?

SCORE

0

1

2

WHY IT MATTERS

“Everyone’s job” is nobody’s job. AI and automation aren’t set-and-forget — they need an owner to monitor, correct, and improve them. Unowned systems quietly rot.

READY WHEN

One accountable person is named, has time allocated, and understands both the business goal and the tool.

DO THIS

Name the owner before you buy. If no one has capacity to own it, you’re not ready to run it.

WARNING SIGNS

No named owner. “IT will handle it” (but IT wasn’t consulted). The plan ends at launch.

6

Have you considered risks, exceptions, and edge cases?

SCORE

0

1

2

WHY IT MATTERS

The average case is easy. The value — and the danger — lives in the exceptions. AI handles the middle well and the edges badly.

READY WHEN

You’ve listed the main exceptions, decided how each is handled, and know which cases must route to a human.

DO THIS

Write down the five ways this could go wrong and what happens in each. Decide what the AI must never do alone.

WARNING SIGNS

The plan only covers the “happy path.” No one has asked “what happens when it’s wrong?”

7

Is human judgment still in the loop where it matters?

SCORE

0

1

2

WHY IT MATTERS

The goal is to remove the repetitive work, not the judgment. Fully delegating decisions that need human context or accountability is where growing companies get burned.

READY WHEN

You know what the AI supports vs. decides, and a human reviews anything customer-facing, financial, or regulated.

DO THIS

Draw the line: list what the AI decides, what it drafts for a human, and what it must never touch.

WARNING SIGNS

The pitch is “it runs itself.” Customer-facing or financial decisions are fully handed to the tool. No review step.

8

Can you measure success?

SCORE

0

1

2

WHY IT MATTERS

If you can't measure it, you can't tell whether it worked — and you'll kill a good tool or keep a bad one. A baseline before you start is the only way to prove value.

READY WHEN

Today's numbers are written down — hours, error rate, cost, cycle time — and you know what improvement justifies the spend.

DO THIS

Record the baseline this week. Pick the one number that decides keep-or-kill.

WARNING SIGNS

No baseline. Success means “it feels faster.” No agreed number to hit.

9 Can the business maintain the solution over time?

SCORE

WHY IT MATTERS

Tools drift. Data changes, staff turn over, vendors update the product. A solution nobody can maintain becomes a liability the moment the person who set it up leaves.

READY WHEN

The setup is documented, more than one person can run it, and there's a plan for updates and support.

DO THIS

Require documentation and a second trained person before you call it “done.”

WARNING SIGNS

Only the consultant or one employee understands it. No documentation. No plan for updates or vendor changes.

10 Does the expected value justify the cost?

SCORE

WHY IT MATTERS

The real cost includes the subscription, the setup, and the change effort. The real value is the time given back — and what your team does with it.

READY WHEN

You've weighed hours saved × cost against total cost, and the payback is defensible to a partner or a board.

DO THIS

Run it: hours saved/week × loaded hourly cost × 50 weeks vs. annual cost. Under ~6 months payback and low risk → go.

WARNING SIGNS

The only justification is “it's AI” or “competitors are doing it.” No payback estimate. Cost of change ignored.

YOUR RESULT

Add it up.

Total readiness score

_____ / 20

- 0-7
NOT READY

Focus on process clarity and ownership before buying technology — AI now would amplify the gaps, not close them. This is good news: the fixes are cheaper than the tools, and they pay off with or without AI.
- 8-14
PARTIALLY READY

A narrow, well-scoped pilot may fit — after you close your two or three lowest-scoring questions. Don't go broad yet. Prove it on one task, measure it, then decide.
- 15-20
READY

You're prepared to prioritize use cases and build a real implementation plan. Your risk now is doing too much at once — sequence it, and keep measuring.

Whatever your score, the lowest-scoring questions are your roadmap. Fix those first — in order.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Your score is a starting point, not a verdict.

Most growing companies land in the middle — and the middle is exactly where the right first move creates outsized value. NexDyne Consulting Group helps growing companies evaluate readiness, prioritize the highest-value opportunities, and build responsible, measurable implementation plans. Human intelligence, governed and scaled.

Apply this to your business

Request an AI & Operations Readiness Assessment — we run this framework on your company and hand you a prioritized, honest plan.

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